

13 Sustainability and Organizational Change

An Institutional Perspective

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Introduction

Sustainability, as we mean it, refers to “development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs” (Bruntland, 1987: 43). If one assumes that moving towards sustainability represents a significant form of organizational change, then there are two overarching approaches that can be taken about how that change might be accomplished. The two approaches are distinguished by whether they focus upon the organizational or the institutional level of analysis. The former—the organizational level—approach asks how any such important organizational change can be achieved, wittingly? That is, it asks what senior managers can and should (usually) “do” if they wish to fundamentally change an organization—i.e., to move it from one state (such as one that is unresponsive to issues of sustainability) to another (where sustainability figures prominently)? This approach considers aspects of the organization—such as its structural complexity, its existing resource commitments, the reproductive impulse of on-going routines, and the play of political resistance—as problematical obstacles, and explores the role of managers in framing change strategies so as to overcome them. Leaders of organizations are portrayed as important players in orchestrating change.

The second—institutional level—approach is very different. This approach emphasizes the contextual (rather than intra-organizational) circumstances that enable, push, or inhibit organizations from moving from one state to another. The actions of managers within organizations, whether deliberate or otherwise, are seen as secondary in this change process. Broader, socio-cultural factors are at work in defining and legitimating acceptable organizational ideas and behaviors, particularly deeply engrained ones. As such, managers play only one of two roles in this institutional process. A hard institutional stance portrays them as “puppets” or “dupes” acting out, unthinkingly, taken-for-granted prescriptions. A softer, more agentic stance sees managers as interpreting and shaping those prescriptions, even if

managers are not normally the driving force behind them (Barley, 2008; Maguire and Hardy, 2008). As a result of our own research on institutional theory (for example, Greenwood et al., 2011) and sustainability (for example, Hardy and Maguire, 2008), we lean more towards the latter, more nuanced position.

Institutional accounts seem well matched with the macro level of analysis involved in sustainability and with the degree of difficulty in achieving it. This chapter puts forward an institutional account of organizational change focused upon the challenge of introducing and embedding ideas of sustainability. In doing so, we emphasize sustainability from an environmental point of view, while acknowledging that environmental sustainability entails social sustainability (for example, see McWilliams and Siegel, 2011). We begin in the section “Institutional change” by outlining the institutional perspective and in particular what it says about the challenge of introducing change. We trace the shift from the perspective’s early emphasis upon stability and institutional maintenance to more recent analyses that highlight the circumstances and mechanisms that enable, indeed trigger and promote, institutional and organizational change. We ask how this perspective indicates the means by which the ideas and practices of sustainability could become taken for granted and widely practiced. We then turn to an institutional account of organizational change and conclude by suggesting six implications of importance for senior managers seeking to improve their organization’s sustainability.

Institutional change

BEGINNINGS

While not the earliest model of institutional change (for example, see Weber, 1922 [1919] or Selznick, 1949) the work of Meyer and Rowan (1977), Meyer and Scott (1983), and DiMaggio and Powell (2000) launched a line of work that received sufficient consensus to be identified as the most widespread early model of institutional change (for a review, see Greenwood et al., 2008). Meyer and Rowan observed that, within any given sector or industry, organizations use similar organizational forms. They explained this observation by pointing to the influence of the social context within which organizations are embedded. That context contains “powerful institutional rules” that define appropriate and acceptable forms of organizing.

In effect, Meyer and Rowan alerted theorists to the fact that organizations are not simply production systems, functioning in an environment comprised of suppliers, consumers, and competitors, but social and cultural systems embedded within an “institutional” context, comprising social expectations and prescriptions of what constitutes appropriate (“legitimate”) behavior,

supported by an institutional infrastructure of actors including the state, professions, interest groups, the media, public opinion and so forth, that monitored and cajoled organizations to adopt those behaviors. The behavior of organizations, in consequence, cannot be understood without taking into account the influence of this institutional context. Moreover, this influence is resonant and resilient. Organizations are not free-floating islands of rationality or units of political expediency; instead, they are seriously constrained by social expectations and the properties of legitimacy. In examining how or why individual organizations adopt new ideas or practices, it is thus necessary to understand the role and consequences of these field-level isomorphic and policing mechanisms.

From its early days, institutional analyses have focused upon *field-level* processes. Fields are "...a community of organizations that partakes of a common meaning system and whose participants interact more frequently and fatefully with one another than with actors outside the field" (Scott, 1995: 56). The idea of fields having "common meaning" systems has since become associated with the idea of "institutional logics" (Friedland and Alford, 1991; Thornton et al., 2012), defined as sets of reasonably coherent socially constructed rules, norms, and beliefs that define field membership, specify institutional or "collective" identities (Glynn, 2008) and that lay down patterns of appropriate conduct. Logics, in this sense, shape how actors interpret reality and provide the criteria for socially "legitimate" behavior. They prescribe and proscribe acceptable collective purposes and the appropriate organizational arrangements by which those purposes should be pursued. Or, as Battilana et al. (2009: 65) simply put it, a logic "is a field's shared understanding of the goals to be pursued and how they are to be pursued."

While market, religion, family, and community were all domains of social life that could be assessed at the field level and that had logics governing them (see Thornton et al., 2012 for a review), in the early model of institutions the natural environment was only implicitly, not explicitly, acknowledged as being part of these domains. Weber (1913, 1922)—and much later Scott and Meyer (1983)—underscored the naturalistic components of institutional orders and that various domains, such as religion, with its naturalistic underpinnings, might influence market domains. Similarly, Selznick (1949) documented that values followed by community leaders were an extension of the domains in which leaders operated—in the case of the TVA, highly agrarian ones. Yet it was not until the mid-1990s that a few institutional theorists explicitly proposed that the natural environment could be assessed as a field (or parts of fields) and that logics governed the operation of the natural environment in those fields (for example, Jennings and Zandbergen, 1995; Frank, 1997; Hoffman, 1999).

THE EARLY MODEL OF INSTITUTIONAL CHANGE: PRESCRIPTIONS AND CONVERGENCE

Contained within these early expressions of institutional theory is a process model of *convergent* change built around prescriptions and convergence, as was first explicated by Tolbert and Zucker (1983): for a later articulation, see Tolbert et al. (1996); for a review of subsequent work, see Boxenbaum and Jonsson (2008). Tolbert and Zucker examined the diffusion of personnel reforms across municipalities in the US and suggested that institutionalization follows three identifiable stages: *pre-institutionalization* (habitualization); *semi-institutionalization* (objectification); and *institutionalization* (sedimentation). Pre-institutionalization is the emergence of behaviors specific to a problem. Although some imitation between organizations may occur, there is no sense of obligation to do so; on the contrary, behaviors are appraised for their pragmatic functionality (i.e., whether they work). Knowledge of a new organizational arrangement, moreover, is restricted to small numbers of neighboring or interlocked organizations.

Eventually, in this model of change, a social consensus emerges over the value of particular social arrangements, followed by increasing rates of their adoption. In this semi-institutionalization stage, diffusion occurs because organizations mimic those perceived to be successful, but eventually the motivation to adopt shifts to a “more normative base” (Tolbert et al., 1996: 183). That is, the more that a new arrangement is adopted, the more it becomes regarded as an appropriate response and acquires cognitive legitimacy. There is too, the emergence of a supporting infrastructure of institutional intermediaries and referent audiences (associations, critics, consultants, etc.) that detail and enforce social prescriptions. Full institutionalization occurs when diffusion is almost universal and the new arrangement has become taken for granted. At this point, organizations within a field are not only constrained by institutional intermediaries, but, in their behaviors, act out and thus reproduce those structures, albeit sometimes imperfectly (Barley and Tolbert, 1997).

For sustainability advocates, this earlier model of institutional change is discouraging because it implies that long-standing arrangements that deny sustainability ideas and practices, sustainability as a logic, and institutional mechanisms for sustainability will be difficult to change (Hoffman and Ventresca, 2002). A more optimistic stance, however, is to see this earlier model as highlighting the factors that could be targeted if change were to be secured (Jennings and Zandbergen, 1995; Frank et al., 2000). It spotlights the importance of social legitimacy and the importance of field-level infrastructures that can inhibit or encourage organizational change. It implies that, if legitimation of “sustainability” as a central or complementary logic in a field could be garnered, then the adoption, diffusion, and longevity of sustainability ideas and practices would be more likely to be assured.

THE MORE RECENT MODEL OF INSTITUTIONAL CHANGE: COMPLEXITY AND DIVERGENCE

In fact, institutional change does occur. Prodded by DiMaggio (1991), institutional theorists have sought to understand the circumstances by which such change unfolds. Making sense of this extensive and sprawling literature is difficult (for a review, see Greenwood et al., 2008; Battilana et al., 2009), but two questions have attracted attention and are of relevance to our purpose here. First, where and how do initiatives that challenge existing logics initially arise? Put another way, how does “reflexivity” occur, thus opening up possibilities and places for institutional change? Second, how are new ideas successfully “theorized” and accorded legitimacy? If a central prerequisite of institutional change is to incorporate or reprioritize a new logic, how is that accomplished? Once these questions have been asked, attention can then turn to understanding why some organizations are receptive to new ideas whereas other organizations are more resistant to them. The following discussion of these issues is summarized in the institutional model of organizational change depicted in Figure 13.1.

Question 1—reflexivity

Given the emphasis of early institutional accounts upon taken-for-granted logics and their associated practices, the starting point for any theory of institutional change has to be an account of how and why some actors are able to exercise “reflexivity”—that is, *how they get “outside” prevailing ideas and consider alternatives*. This is the “paradox of embedded agency” (Battilana et al., 2009). Three approaches to this paradox have been developed.

The first and earliest approach sees reflexivity occurring as a response to exogenous “jolts” (Meyer, 1982; Meyer et al., 1990). The exogenous jolts that have been examined include world wars (Baron et al., 1986; Dobbin, 1992), social upheavals (Skogpol, 1994; Voss and Sherman, 2000) and the entry of

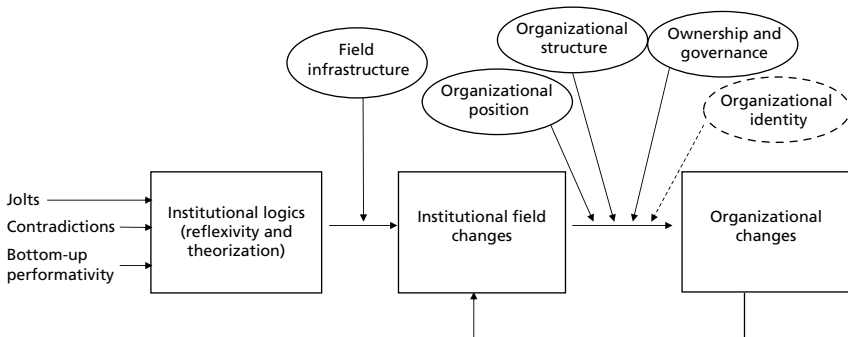


Figure 13.1. The newer model of institutional change

new players into an organizational field (Starr, 1982; DiMaggio, 1988; Thornton and Ocasio, 2008). In the case of sustainability, technical failures—such as nuclear accidents (Perrow, 1999) or chemical spills (Weir, 1987)—lead to reflexivity. The basic thesis is that such jolts disturb preconceived and taken-for-granted ideas and prompt reflection about possible alternative ways of doing things—much as profoundly erratic weather shifts have precipitated wider consideration of climate change.

A second explanation for the occurrence of reflexivity builds upon the idea that fields contain multiple logics, and proposes that reflexivity and deinstitutionalization arise not from exogenous shocks but from endogenous tensions and contradictions within a field (Jennings and Zandbergen, 1995; Seo and Creed, 2002; also see Giddens, 1984). According to Friedland and Alford (1991), society is composed of several “institutional orders”—such as the market, family, religion—each associated with distinctive institutional logics. Importantly, any organizational field may be subject to the influence of more than one institutional order and thus of multiple logics. Moreover, sometimes these logics are—or are assumed to be—contradictory in their implications. Organizations thus face the challenge of coping with incompatible institutional demands. Those located at the interstices of competing logics are especially likely to perceive opportunities for change, especially if their identity is not conditional upon one logic rather than another. Hoffman (1997: 1999), for example, documented how various logics of environmental management (for example, industrial, regulatory, CSR, and strategic) arose in the chemical industry after periods of contestation, each logic only partly embodying elements of the prior logic.

The third and more recent approach to reflexivity focuses upon initiatives and improvisations—often unplanned and often loosely coordinated—that arise in the “performativity” of day-to-day “practices” (for example, Lounsbury and Crumley, 2007; Smets et al., 2012). Such “bottom-up” improvisations are driven by the need to get things done—as illustrated by Zietsma and Lawrence in their study of forest practice code elaboration, which preceded the forestry field’s transformation (Zietsma and Lawrence, 2010). According to these studies, modifications to practices can arise and slowly coalesce and crystallize at the “coalface” (Barley, 2008) into new ways of doing things. Under certain circumstances, these coalface improvisations become adopted more formally by the host organization and subsequently move to the level of the field. The common conclusion of the practice improvisation approach is that change is both highly dispersed in its origins and heterogeneous in the forms that it takes. Hence, there is continual improvisation, learning, and thus reflexivity.

As accounts of reflexivity—whether arising from exogenous shocks, endogenous contradictions, or bottom-up performativity—and its role in institutional change have developed, an important shift in imagery has occurred (and one that has implications for our later discussion of *organizational change*). The early imagery implied that field-level institutional change was

the replacement of one dominant logic by another—even though it has long been recognized that organizations typically face multiple logics (for example, see D'Aunno et al., 1991; Hoffman, 1999). The more recent imagery accepts the *on-going* (albeit, possibly contested) presence of *multiple* logics. Instead of fields being portrayed as fundamentally stable, they are depicted as persistently in flux—“legitimacy is not a state but a constant struggle” (Rozbicki, 1998: 25)—although the likelihood and pace of change has been observed to vary from field to field (Delbridge and Edwards, 2008; Marquis and Lounsbury, 2007; Thornton and Ocasio, 2008; Purdy and Gray, 2009; Reay and Hinings, 2009; Dunn and Jones, 2010). Nevertheless, “institutional complexity” (Greenwood et al., 2011), rather than enduring institutional homogeneity is now seen as increasingly common and as the mechanism of institutional change.

The emergence of sustainability fits well with this research thrust in that it is often portrayed as an attempt to somehow reconcile/blend/balance two or more logics—usually those of business efficiency (a market logic) and some form of environmental and/or community logic (Bansal, 2005; Hoffman and Jennings, 2011; Jennings et al., 2012). Sustainability, in this sense, is usually not seen as being very compatible with existing economic logics in most industrial sectors (Gladwin et al., 1995; Hulme, 2009). Instead, it is viewed as a logic and set of prescriptions in competition with extant economic practice.

Question 2—“theorization”

By itself, reflexivity is not a sufficient condition for institutional change. Theorization is also needed and is, we propose, distinctive of the institutional perspective. Tolbert et al. (1996) propose that theorization involves two major tasks: specification of a general organizational failing, in order to challenge the adequacy of existing arrangements; and justification of new organizational arrangements as a widely appropriate solution. Theorization is thus the rendering of ideas into compelling formats and is critical for the ascription of legitimacy to them (Strang and Meyer, 1993). It is the process whereby new ideas and practices gain legitimacy and the means by which “renegotiations of meaning take place” (Aldrich and Fiol, 1994: 649). Successful theorization “increases the zones of acceptance by creating perceptions of similarity among adopters and by providing rationales for the practices to be adopted” (Rao et al., 2003). For example, the creation of new categories related to sustainability backed by key constituents further enables the acceptance process. Such is the case with “grass-fed” beef, as supported by local ranchers and consumers over “normally raised” beef, which was often for less local consumption (Weber et al., 2008). Theorization, thus, is the stage where competing versions like grass-fed versus normally raised struggle for superiority. The contribution of institutional theory is the attention it gives to socio-cultural processes and, increasingly, the rhetoric of language connected to higher-order institutional logics as means by which novelty is rendered acceptable and preferable

(Suddaby and Greenwood, 2005). These linguistic-discursive processes attach social approval to novelty.

Birkinshaw et al. (2008) remind us that theorization is necessary both within an organization and externally. Because of their especial interest in field-level processes, however, most institutional analyses attend to the latter in the attempt to understand how institutional (rather than organizational) change is theorized, and have centered their attention upon two more specific questions regarding theorization: “*Who* can successfully theorize?” and “*How* do they do so?”

Who can theorize? Several theorizing agents have been identified: management consultants (Abrahamson, 1991; Sahlin-Anderson and Engwall, 2002), the media (Davis, et al., 1994; Rao et al., 2003) professional associations (Greenwood et al., 2002; Jones, Maoret, Massa and Svejenova, 2012; Goodrick and Reay, 2010), corporations (Munir and Phillips, 2005), critics and journalists (Rao, Morin and Durand, 2003), and historians (Khaire and Wadhvani, 2010)—to which might be added academics. Especial emphasis has been placed upon the role of social movements as agents of theorization (for a review, see Schneiberg and Lounsbury, 2008). For example, in their study of DDT, Maguire and Hardy (2009) note how opponents of DDT discursively problematized its use. This external theorization, of which Rachael Carlson’s *Silent Spring* is but one example, put pressure on the industry to defend its practices (Maguire and Hardy, 2009; Hoffman and Jennings, 2011).

The list of theorizing agents is long, but not all actors/organizations are equally successful in commanding attention, for which various explanations have been offered—including references to an organization’s status, its size and visibility, and its ability to deploy resources (cultural, political, financial, and formal regulatory authority). Common to successful theorization efforts, however, is that proponents have “discursive legitimacy” (Hardy and Phillips, 1998). That is, that they are acknowledged by members of the field as having the right to exercise “voice.”

The importance of having discursive legitimacy is highlighted in Lefsrud and Meyer’s (2012) examination of the climate change debate, which shows the role and frames of professional engineers and geophysicists in creating variance in the meaning of climate change and its associated risks. This study reveals that certain segments of scientists have become useful tools for skeptics of climate change because they have legitimacy as scientists (also see Hoffman and Jennings, 2011). The general point is that for successful theorization to occur the identity (and thus the legitimacy) of those theorizing the need for change matters, and that the legitimacy of sustainability as a new logic depends upon the nature of their association and identification with the logics in play.

How do they theorize? Much recent work has examined *how* theorization is accomplished. For the most part, these studies focus upon the use of cultural

symbols and language—"discourse" (Phillips et al., 2004)—as proponents and opponents contest the appropriateness of existing and nascent templates of behavior (Greenwood et al., 2002; Maguire et al., 2004; Suddaby and Greenwood, 2005). The role of language in the theorization process is regarded as "fundamental" because "discourses make certain ways of thinking and acting possible, and others impossible or costly" (Phillips et al., 2004: 638; see also Clark and Jennings, 1997). Language, in other words, is a means "to persuade constituencies of the desirability and appropriateness of institutional deviance" (Suddaby and Greenwood, 2005: 37). Successful institutional entrepreneurs, therefore, are those "skilled enough to craft a compelling message advocating for change" (Etzion and Ferraro, 2010: 1092; Lefsrud and Jennings, forthcoming).

But how is a compelling message constructed? One line of study draws upon social movement theory and its emphasis upon "framing." Lounsbury (2001), for example, shows how a viable infrastructure for recycling did not develop until activists reframed (re-theorized) recycling as a *for-profit* service; that is, the framing had to connect with the interests and market logic of critical players in order to garner legitimacy. Similarly, Weber et al. (2009) report how the anti-genetic movement in Germany "described biotechnology as a threat not only to the environment but to the moral good of pure untouched nature, and they tapped into a deep-seated suspicion of eugenics..." It was the use of these "culturally resonant frames" that helped to mobilize support and provided access to critical resource holders and influential decision makers.

Etzion and Ferraro (2010), in their longitudinal study of the Global Reporting Initiative for sustainability reporting practices, highlight two particularly successful "discursive strategies" deployed in the sustainability debate. One strategy used the analogy of financial reporting in order to associate a sustainability "audit" with an already highly legitimated practice (even drawing verbatim from the International Standard Committee Board's reporting principles). The second strategy framed "social ills and environmental degradation... as issues that have an impact on businesses' economic performance," in order to distance ("decouple") the GRI guidelines "from the more politically sensitive agenda of sustainability" (Etzion and Ferraro, 2010: 1,100).

A second line of inquiry into how theorization can be accomplished draws upon rhetorical theory (for example, Green, 2004; Suddaby and Greenwood, 2005; Erkama and Vaara, 2010; Goodrick and Reay, 2010). Green (2004) distinguishes between three forms of "discursive justification"—*pathos* (an appeal to emotion), *logos* (an appeal to logic and pragmatic legitimacy), and *ethos* (an appeal to ethical legitimacy)—and discusses their implications for persuasion. For example, *pathos* is high on attention capture but is transient in its effects, whereas appeals to *ethos* are more durable, but low on attention capture (although, see Bansal, 2005). Hence, Green suggests that the sequence in the use of these justifications will affect the success or otherwise of theorization efforts. An example of the aligning of language to the setting is

contained in studies documenting the relationship between regulatory processes and the field-level diffusion of affirmative action and due process (Dobbin, 1992, 1993; Edelman, 1990, 1992; Edelman et al., 1992; Dobbin et al., 1993; Edelman and Suchman, 1997). Given the ambiguity of regulatory policies, including environmental ones, personnel practitioners interpreted those practices and persuaded managers that they should be perceived not as “red tape” but as ways of improving efficiency (for example, by better linking employee skills to jobs and responsibilities). Recently, in their large-scale study of several thousand French firms, Delmas and Pekovic (2013) documented the importance of human resource managers’ commitment and creation of training programs in order to realize productivity gains following the adoption of ISO 14001 policies.

Before leaving this discussion of theorization, a final point that deserves mention is that successful theorization is not simply the skilful linguistic appeal to higher-order values and ideals. It also has a political dimension, as pointed out by Maguire et al. (2004: 671; see also Zilber, 2008; Jennings et al., 2013):

...in addition to persuasively theorizing the new practices they are promoting as logical solutions to identified problems, institutional entrepreneurs in emerging fields need also to theorize political chains of cause and effect. They must make clear to stakeholders the political consequences of supporting or not supporting the new practices.

By drawing attention to political theorization, Maguire et al. (2004) are doing two things. First, they are reminding us that institutional change is not achieved solely through the use of persuasive language. Institutions are not simply the cognitive outcomes of discursive struggles but are “settlements of political struggles...fuelled by the mobilization of challenges around competitive projects and logics” (Schneiberg and Lounsbury, 2008). Actions, in other words, are also involved. Sometimes these actions are highly contentious, as shown by Hoffman’s study of “institutional war” in the US chemical industry (1999). Developments in Alberta’s Oil Sands (Coleman et al., 2012), such as the proposed XL pipeline from Alberta to Texas, is another example of a highly contentious struggle involving actions and discourse. Actors within the field’s boundary employ highly creative, yet oppositional tactics to buffer the field from outside interests, such as e-non-governmental organizations or high-profile others, such as James Cameron, who has been publically critical of the Oil Sands. Second, Maguire and Hardy are accentuating that theorization of a particular case—such as the importance of sustainability and the threat posed by expanding Oil Sands development—involves not simply rhetorical skill, but the spelling out of the political implications for those ultimately responsible for policies and regulatory decisions.

FIELD INFRASTRUCTURE AS A TYPE OF “MODERATING” EFFECT

Thus far, the argument has been that institutional change is the consequence of disturbance to the underpinning logics within an organizational field. That

disturbance, which may arise from exogenous shocks, endogenous contradictions, or bottom-up performativity, precipitates reflexivity. If accompanied by successful theorization, institutional change may occur. For the sustainability debate, it means that reflexivity—the problematizing of existing arrangements—has to be accomplished through persuasive theorization by discursively legitimated advocates. Importantly, this link between reflexivity and theorization on the one hand, and institutional change on the other, is influenced by the infrastructure of the organizational field, which can enable or hinder change and may shape its pace and linearity. Some fields are more receptive to change than others. For example, Purdy and Gray (2009) argue that a field with relatively little structure—i.e. the absence of associations, conferences, etc.—means that organizational norms and practices will be poorly specified, allowing for competing logics to exist and to engage in continual contestation and struggle. In contrast, Jennings et al. (2005) show that the development of a legal infrastructure around water laws goes hand in hand with the elaboration of water law regulations and their application, with regulation stimulating further bureaucratization of water administration via the need for rule refinement and interpretation.

Despite the importance of field infrastructures, it is beyond the scope of this chapter to review in detail what we know (which is rather modest) about field-level differences (for a summary, see Scott, 2001; Greenwood et al., 2011). But it is worth noting the recent interest in “field-configuring events” (FCEs), such as trade shows, conferences, award ceremonies, and tournaments; and in government support institutions (GSIs) such as public research institutes and training centers (see McDermott et al., 2009). Lampel and Meyer (2008) highlight the significance of FCEs in developing and diffusing novel ideas. These temporary social organizations are significant because they are vehicles for discursive struggles. They are particularly important in developing social networks that allow for the expression and dissemination of new ideas and the social reconstruction of norms and standards. As such, they are mechanisms that bring together actors to reshape fields (Anand and Jones, 2008). Maguire and Hardy (2009) note that FCEs provide those rare and important time-compressed opportunities for the interaction of actors holding different visions of the future. Participants in FCEs produce accounts and “narratives” that describe the way that fields should be theorized and organized, and provide opportunities for proponents of novel ideas to access and persuade those with power to give legitimacy to new practices (McInerney, 2008; Thornton et al., 2012). Schüßler et al. (2013), for example, have shown the role of FCEs as catalysts of change for climate policy. But in doing so they highlight the importance of the specific conditions in which debate occurs. Climate change conferences organized by the UN, for example, may paradoxically prevent as well as allow the embedding of field-level change, depending upon the structure of the conferences. For change to occur, “interactional openness” (which generates learning and trust) has to be combined with “temporal boundedness” (which generates creativity and momentum).

Organizational change

At the level of the organization, institutionalists have explored two themes. The earliest theme examines the heterogeneity of organizational responses to similar institutional contexts and asks why organizations differ in their *receptivity* to new ideas/logics. Why, for example, do some organizations more willingly adopt practices that promote environmental sustainability, whereas others remain highly resistant? Put another way, why are only some organizations embracing the sustainability logic? The central insight for institutional theory to this line of questions is that receptivity to any logic is affected by various organizational attributes that work as filters upon how institutional demands are interpreted and understood. A more recent theme explores how profound change can be *implemented*.

ORGANIZATIONAL RECEPTIVITY

It is known that organizations do not respond uniformly to institutional demands. The early portrayal within institutional theory of organizations converging upon a common archetypal set of practices is now seen as an oversimplification. Instead, organizations vary in their responses, albeit within circumscribed limits. In consequence, the need to understand the heterogeneity of organizational responses to seemingly similar institutional demands has moved to the forefront of recent institutional discussion (Lounsbury, 2001; Marquis and Lounsbury, 2007; Delbridge and Edwards, 2008; Thornton and Ocasio, 2008; Purdy and Gray, 2009; Reay and Hinings, 2009; Dunn and Jones, 2010; Pache and Santos, 2010; Thornton et al., 2012). Much of this research examines how and why organizations make sense of multiple prescriptions and proscriptions that are pushed upon them by field-level processes.

For us, the question of how and why organizations respond to the sustainability logic is an inquiry into the *relationship* between an organization and the field (or fields) in which it operates. What happens inside the organization, in other words, is, for the most part, the consequence of those relationships. The ties that link an organization to its institutional context affect how an organization will understand and respond to ideas about appropriate behavior. And, those relationships/ties are structured, in part, by various attributes of the organization which “filter” institutional signals. Four attributes in particular have been highlighted: the organization’s *position* within a field; its organizational *structure*; its form of *ownership and governance*; and its *identity* (Greenwood et al., 2011: 339; also see Scott, 2001).¹

¹ *Identity* is considered quite important by us, but left to other contributors to this volume (e.g., Glynn et al. Chapter 6 Staying the Same While Changing: Organizational Identity in the Face of Environmental Challenges) to discuss in detail.

Field position

One of the earliest interpretations of why some organizations are more open to new ideas and practices centers upon the implication of an organization's "structural position" within a field. This interpretation has two variants, but they share the common theme that some organizations are both more embedded—and thus caught—within existing institutional arrangements. Embedded firms are, in institutional terms, "central," whereas others are more "peripheral" (Leblebici et al., 1991; Rao et al., 2000; Maguire et al., 2004). The thesis is that organizations on the periphery will be less informed by and/or knowledgeable of prevailing logics and thus more likely to exercise reflexivity and be willing to accommodate pressures for change. Centrally located firms, in contrast, are more aware of institutional expectations, are more fully and continually exposed to the social reproduction of those expectations, benefit more from them, and thus are more fully embedded. Moreover, centrally located firms are often highly visible and subject to detailed critical scrutiny from field-level audiences such as the media, which can work to keep them within the bounds of dominant logics (for an interesting example of this process, see Ahmadjian and Robinson, 2001, who show how large, elite Japanese firms were the most reluctant to abandon the traditional commitment to permanent employment). Several studies confirm this general thesis of peripheral players as the more likely source of "institutional entrepreneurship" (for a review, see Hardy and Maguire, 2008). An interesting sustainability example is Sine and Lee's (2009) study of wind power adoption, which shows the critical, joint role played by independent power producers and environmental social movements in building this new industry "off grid," then gradually linking it to the main sources of power production.

A counter to this view of peripheral organizations as being more receptive than central organizations to new logics is provided by Greenwood and Suddaby (2006; also see Greenwood et al., 2002), who detail how elite (central) firms within the accounting industry responded to, and co-developed new patterns of service and an organizational form that rebalanced the traditional professional logic with a more commercial logic. An interesting insight from this study is that central firms are often more able to exercise reflexivity because their networks of contacts "bridge" institutional fields and thus bring them into contact with new ideas and practices; *and* they are often sufficiently large that they are beyond the reach and scope of a field's regulatory agencies. Hoffman (2001), for example, has argued that the creation and adoption of new environmental practices by core players in the chemical industry, along with their linkage to government sanctions (laws, regulations, and enforcement) have been fundamental for the rise of new environmental management logics in that industry.

Organizational structure

Ideas do not simply “flow into” an organization. Institutional prescriptions and demands are “carried” by actors. Early institutional studies, for example, looked at the role of interlocking directorates as carriers of ideas (Davis, 1991; Palmer et al., 1993). Recent work has broadened this thesis that ideas—new and old—need “representation” within an organization if they are to have influence (Pache and Santos, 2010). That is, the receptivity of an organization to new ideas—such as sustainability—is, in part, dependent upon whether proponents of those ideas reside within the organization. New logics, it is argued, need championing within the organization by “representatives” if they are to have influence beyond ceremonial acknowledgment (Pache and Santos, 2010). Pursuing this idea, institutionalists have explored the role of different actors within organizations. For example, in their study of large Canadian firm environmental practice, Sharma and Henriques (2005) documented the association between different types of firms with different types of stakeholders (for example, reactive with media and proactive with community). Bansal and Roth (2000) showed that, in addition to regulatory pressure and economic good sense, corporate leadership’s commitment to sustainability was an important reason for companies going green. Similarly, Lounsbury (2001) found that universities that have made the greater commitment to waste recycling are the ones that employ staff with the relevant expertise and thus who have the commitment to develop and advocate for the introduction of new, more sustainable practices. A key point of these studies is that organizational receptivity to the prescriptions of different logics depends upon their formal and explicit representation within the firm.

However, representation alone is only part of the story. An assumption of the representation thesis is that “representatives” retain their commitment to particular ideas and that they continue to enhance their understanding of them. Yet, it has been shown that this assumption is questionable. Gabbioneta et al. (2013), for example, observed that professionals in large organizations, especially those with high status, may be more susceptible to gentle pressure to compromise their professional norms because such organizations provide a form of “structural assurance” that its actions are acceptable. Similarly, Flood (2012: 192; see also Lewis, 1990; Smets et al., 2012) reports that large law firms “incubate their lawyers to act in particular ways.” Hence, as Greenwood et al., (2011: 342) point out:

...the receptivity of organizational members to a given logic is affected by the thickness of ties—such as conference attendance, club memberships, training programs, etc.—linking them to the field-level institutional infrastructure... what matters, in other words, is not simply whether a logic is represented within an organization, but the thickness of the ties between organization members and field-level referent audiences; the thicker the tie, the more likely the logic will insinuate itself into the organization.

Hoffman's work on environmental NGOs (Hoffman, 2011; Hoffman and Bertels, 2007) neatly develops and illustrates these points. In the US, *eNGOs are tightly networked in particular cliques that include particular Fortune 500 firms*. As a result, the F500 firms' policies regarding the environment come to reflect the policies of these cliques (Hoffman and Bertels, 2007). In fact, the way in which the science of climate change is portrayed and by whom is also affected by such eNGO networks (Hoffman and Bertels, 2007; Lefsrud and Meyer, 2012).

The importance of ties between an organization and the field-level institutional infrastructure is not solely concerned with the latter providing normative and material support. As pointed out earlier, field-level actors—such as professional associations—not only provide support, they monitor and *police* implementation (Jennings et al., 2002). Connections between firms and field-level agencies can thus assist in the evolution and on-going retention of contested logics. The effectiveness of collective self-regulation, however, is by no means assured. King and Lenox (2000: 702) summarized the institutional argument underpinning self-regulation:

The essence of this argument is that the institutional structure that accompanies self-regulation can control behavior through more informal coercive, normative, and mimetic means... First, coercion can be achieved through more informal mechanisms, such as showing or public exposure... Second, self-regulation can support the emergence of new norms and values that change members' preferences for collectively valued actions... Finally, when collectively valued actions are also privately beneficial, industry self-regulation can facilitate the transfer of best practices...

Evidence from King and Lenox's study of the US chemical industry, however, is, at best, equivocal. Bansal and Roth (2000) suggest that whether firms comply with field regulations depends in part upon "field coherence," an idea also found in Pache and Santos (2013a), who stress that it is "centralized" fields—that is, those where there is a clearly dominant institutional logic—that are able to monitor and police the behavior of field members. In fields characterized by multiple incompatible logics where there is a lack of an accepted status hierarchy between logics, the ability of field agencies to monitor and enforce institutional demands is problematic. As Crilly et al. (2012) point out: "Competing stakeholder expectations... weaken the pressures on firm to comply with policy and thus increase their discretion over how to respond." Crilly et al. (2012) go further and emphasize that there is often an asymmetry of information favoring organizations (over field-level actors), which enables them to conceal their responses from regulatory agencies. Similarly, in fields where there is a transition among plural logics, there is often a lack of clarity about legal rules (laws and regulation), which increases the likelihood that actors might engage in non-compliance and lowers the enforcement intensity by government agencies (Jennings et al., 2002, 2011).

Ownership

A different approach to understanding why some organizations are more receptive to ideas and practices associated with the sustainability logic focuses upon the *type of ownership*. Several studies have shown the significance of *who* owns the firm. Studies have shown how family-owned businesses incorporate into their decisions the norms of “community,” rather than exclusively those of the market logic (for example, Gomez-Mejia et al., 2007; Greenwood et al., 2010). As a result, family firms tend to be better environmental stewards (Berrone et al., 2009). Similarly, religious organizations prioritize particular values, as indicated by Walsh et al. (2003: 874) who found that “religious values that orient Catholic universities might prompt their faculty to focus on a more expansive set of business–society relationships than their peers at universities celebrated by the business community in the *Business Week* rankings.” The form of ownership, in other words, serves to filter and/or give relative salience to incompatible and novel ideas.

A complementary approach to understanding the role of ownership and governance emphasizes not who owns an organization, but the *form* of that ownership (Fligstein, 2001). For example, the partnership form of governance, deployed by law firms and accounting firms, and by not-for-profits, “are distinguished by participation in decision processes that is wider and more inclusive than would be expected in the more hierarchically ordered publicly traded corporation” (Greenwood et al., 2011: 345—hence the higher likelihood of multiple ideas and views being brought into decision processes). For this reason, the partnership format might enable receptivity to new ideas. Alternatively, it has been argued that within professional service firms there can be considerable resistance to the introduction of “corporate” logics because of the norms of collegiality associated with the “partnership” form of ownership and governance (Pinnington and Morris, 2002). In other words, such structures not only allow for participation, they symbolize commitment to collegial forms of behavior (much as do universities) which might act *against* consideration of emerging alternative logics that appear to prioritize more self-interested norms. This assumption guided Lefsrud and Meyer’s (2012) interpretation of the resistant position to climate change data taken by many geophysicists and geologists: if the profession does not accept the data as being sufficiently “scientific,” then the likelihood of the profession embracing open-minded approaches to natural environment issues, actors, and technologies will be low.

There has also been a long-term interest within the social and environmental sustainability literature in whether forms of corporations—particularly, MNCs—are likely to pursue different types of policies and operate differently across non-home countries. Early work seemed to indicate that MNCs would transport pollution and social inequities (for example, low-wage labor) to non-home locations (Cardoso and Faletto, 1979; Piore and Sabel, 1984); but in more recent years, there is evidence of more complex effects (Porter and Van

der Linde, 1995). King and Shaver (2001) showed that while foreign MNCs operating in the US may generate more waste, they also process more waste. In an analysis of GE's portfolio of more versus less environmentally oriented operations, Gehman (2012) found that, over time, GE has spun off the less environmentally sound operations—often internationally—as part of “category cleaning,” though GE still retained arms-length ties with these operations.

IMPLEMENTING ORGANIZATIONAL CHANGE

A central assumption of institutional accounts is that disturbances at the field level create opportunities for actors within organizations to introduce new ideas, or to re-order their relative salience. Ideas of sustainability, in other words, are easier to introduce (they are recognized more readily and accorded more legitimacy) to the extent that field-level debates are occurring. Surprisingly, until relatively recently there have been few studies of *how* such changes are accomplished.

The list of such studies, however, is growing (for example, Lounsbury, 2001; Glynn, 2008; Battilana and Dorado, 2010; Erkama and Vaara, 2010; Spicer and Sewell, 2010; Kellogg, 2011; Smets et al., 2012; Jay, 2013; Wright and Zammuto, 2013) and all of these studies highlight the relationship between organizations and the organizational field—which, as we have pointed out, is distinctive of the institutional theory approach. But they also dig into the organization in an attempt to provide guidance on how change can be successfully introduced. Two approaches illustrate a clearly “institutional” approach to the implementation of organizational change. The first approach, for which we use Kellogg's (2009, 2011) work as an example, in many ways reflects the themes of field-level change. The second approach, for which we use as examples the works of Battilana and Dorado (2010) and Pache and Santos (2013b), focuses upon “hybrid” organizations—i.e., organizations that explicitly seek to combine practices and ideas from multiple logics—and attempts to understand how and when such organizations can be successfully deployed.

Implementing organizational change

An apposite illustration of an institutional approach to how organizational change may be accomplished is provided by Kellogg's (2011) analysis of how less powerful members within an organization—in her study, hospital interns—were able to change deeply institutionalized, industry-wide work practices by drawing on field-level discourses. She argues that such change requires the availability *and* the skillful use of cultural *and* political tools:

Cultural toolkits are composed of symbolic elements such as frames, identities and tactics that can be brought into organizations from other settings by any organization

member. In contrast, political toolkits . . . are composed of material elements such as accountability systems, staffing systems, and evaluation systems that depend on the formal authority of more powerful organization members for their introduction into particular organizations. Changes over time in an organization's broader institutional context shape changes in cultural and political toolkits inside organizations. (Kellogg, 2011: 483.)

This study highlighted that organizational change is an expression of the relationship between an organization and its institutional context. For organizational change to occur, reflexivity—an awareness of possibilities—has to be aligned with the skillful use of discursive and political strategies (theorization) so as to persuade audiences of the legitimacy of proposed changes. That is, the legitimacy of ideas depends upon their attachment to the emerging generally accepted social norms *outside* the organization (also see Lounsbury, 2001 on the promotion of recycling in universities).

In an earlier study, Kellogg (2009) highlighted a second requirement of successful organizational change—and, again, it is one that echoes our discussion of field-level change. Kellogg points to the importance of “relational spaces” within hospitals, where junior physicians were able to meet and develop their ideas and their sense of community. These “spaces” could be seen as performing the same role as field-configuring events at the field level. They are the places where otherwise disconnected supporters of new ideas can meet, informally or otherwise, and then build an emerging community of support. The importance of relational spaces is illustrated in Weber et al.'s (2008) analysis of grass-fed beef production. The category system for grass-fed beef classifies producer and consumer relations—i.e., puts a cognitive and normative structure on those relations—which then allows individual organizations to implement these new methods of raising and selling cattle by connecting grass-fed beef products to these categories.

Taken together, the two Kellogg studies illustrate how implementing change at the organizational level *mirrors* the mechanisms and processes observed at the level of the field.

Creating hybrid organizations

A different institutional dig into the implementation of organizational change explores the circumstances that enable the successful use of “hybrid” arrangements. Most organizations are hybrids to some degree, in the sense that they incorporate multiple logics; hospitals and universities are obvious examples. Recent institutional attention to hybrids, however, largely stems from an interest in how organizations cope with the arrival of a new logic, especially one previously considered as incompatible with the dominant organizational purpose and way of operating. The emergence of the sustainability logic is a clear example of a new logic running against an embedded one, in this case the commercial logic.

Hybrids are often seen as “by nature arenas of contestation” (Pache and Santos, 2013b: 2), bringing together “key elements of different logics that may have little in common and may even be in conflict” (Tracey et al., 2011). In many respects, attempts by firms to embrace sustainability practices can be seen in the same light—they are translating themselves into hybrids—i.e., organizations that incorporate both commercial and sustainability logics within their structures and decision processes. For example, Jay (2013) looks at a public–private hybrid that combines the logics of government bureaucracies, non-profit organizations, and business firms as they deal with climate change.

Given the recency of this interest, it is not surprising that understanding of hybrids is modest (for a review, see Battilana and Lee, 2014). Nevertheless, several interesting findings have emerged. Battilana and Dorado (2010) examined two microfinance organizations that sought to combine the logics of business and of poverty alleviation by providing loans for business ventures to low-income entrepreneurs. They found that combining the two logics was highly problematical in one of the two organizations, in which the business logic gradually asserted priority. The successful organization avoided this outcome by hiring personnel whose minds were not captured by either of the two logics, and then used consistent socialization processes to develop a strong organizational identity that gave prominence to both logics. For new organizations, adoption of this prescription for success might be possible, but for established organizations its relevance would be more limited. This study (see also Tracey et al., 2011) indicates the difficulty of retaining a balance between logics, especially when the market logic is involved. That logic—at least in contemporary Western society—tends to exert significant pressure against other logics.

Hence, the challenge of maintaining balance is fundamental to the introduction of sustainability practices. The institutional argument would be that in order to nurture balance and prevent commitment to sustainability becoming ceremonial rather than substantive, two arrangements are essential: first, the appointment of explicit and dedicated proponents (representatives) of the sustainability logic (Lounsbury, 2001); and second, the building of strong ties to field-level proponents of that logic (Greenwood et al., 2011).

Different insights are offered by Pache and Santos (2013a). This study is also concerned with the choice of practices and structures from several logics, but Pache and Santos are interested in how an organization can secure legitimacy from the field-level advocates of incompatible logics; that is, the focus is outward looking, rather than internal to the organization. Pache and Santos compared four French work-integration social enterprises that combined practices of the social welfare logic with practices implicated by the commercial logic. These logics, in the French context, are associated with differences in legal status, ownership structures, profit destination (shareholders versus the enterprise), governance, use of professionals versus volunteers, and so on. Pache and Santos offer two key insights about the

management of hybrids. First, successful hybrids “selectively couple” practices from both logics and blend them together because doing so signals their compliance to the field-level audiences prescribing and monitoring each logic. Hence, they gain legitimacy from both audiences. Second, the particular combination of practices coupled together depends upon the history of the organization. Those organizations that emanated from the commercial sector would, relative to those from the social welfare sector, emphasize the adoption of social welfare practices; whereas those from the social welfare sector would do the opposite and emphasize commercial practices. In other words, recently created hybrids pay special attention to those field-level audiences that are more likely to be skeptical of their intentions.

Most “green organizations” appear to be some form of hybrid: that is, they incorporate sustainability and corporate logics, to varying degrees (Hoffman and Georg, 2011). Research has moved in the direction of examining how this combination has been created and its effects in different types of organizations. This includes giving attention to NGO–business partnerships (Georg and Irwin, 2002; Kong et al., 2002) and public–private partnerships for the environment (Koppenjan and Enserink, 2009). But this research, with the exception perhaps of Henn and Hoffman (2013), has yet to be linked as explicitly to hybridity.

Guidelines for linking institutional change to sustainability

We are now in a position to return more explicitly to some of theoretical implications of our institutional change model for moving a field and a firm towards sustainability—and not simply to use sustainability research as examples for illustrating points about the institutional model. We offer six implications of importance for senior managers seeking to improve their organization’s sustainability.

- 1. Organizational change is significantly dependent upon first generating field-level institutional change.** This is the most fundamental point of our approach. It implies that a senior manager must view issues like climate change and social inequality as truly field-level problems, ones involving environmental and community logics, and then accept that the manager’s logic is embedded in that field. Senior management policy and action must be positioned around the field’s broader consensus about such issues and how they should be handled. One cannot, for instance, simply ignore data on climate change (for example, CO₂ levels, mean temperature change, sea-level increases, and the disappearance of Arctic ice): one must engage with these data and explain a firm’s degree of acceptance (and non-acceptance) in order to generative distinctive sustainability policies and practices. Rick George of

SUNCOR for years debated the data on climate change, yet acknowledged local impacts and pledged SUNCOR to remediation of them. This distinctive position, in the end, won SUNCOR more friends than enemies among climate change groups.

Given that the popularity of and consensus around such issues as climate change tend to wax and wane, a senior manager must track the issues with opinion polls, consultations, and social media (even Twitter), and s/he must form a dynamic, longitudinal picture of the issues in order to best time his or her organization's action. Generally speaking, a field's constituents are likely to care about the system when the system is increasingly stressed. These stresses are often cyclical (for example, seasonal). Depending on the ecosystems in which the firm is involved, a senior manager should be able to anticipate some of these cycles of attention and pre-empt their negative effects on her/his firm.

2. Field-level change can arise from exogenous (jolts) or endogenous (contradictions and bottom-up performativity) sources. Most environmental sustainability issues start from outside the field via an exogenous shock, but periodic jolts then remain in the field due to reflexivity, theorization, and other knock-on effects concerning the jolts (Misutka et al., 2013). Such is the case of the climate-change associated greenhouse gas GHG problem. It appeared in the field in the mid-1990s with the discussion around the Kyoto Protocol and now is being re-worked in the field in a variety of ways, including through eNGO issues with the degradation of specific ecosystems, like the Arctic, and green party issues about renewable sources of issues. Social sustainability issues, in contrast, tend to start with contradictions in logics. A standard contradiction that leads to social sustainability issues is equality as a value underpinning community logics versus inequality that is part of market logics, for market logics normally require competition and unequal outcomes.

Outside jolts often require more immediate adaptation—even acquiescence—on the part of a senior manager and her/his firm than do inside jolts. Outside jolts often elicit a narrower range of responses, because there is far less time to reflect upon and theorize about them. In contrast, endogenously generated issues usually involve more lead time for and a wider range of responses. A senior manager therefore needs to craft different sets of responses to each type of field-level change. Today, few senior managers of major operations can be found without some version of a crisis management protocol for dealing with climate-related or ecosystems disasters, such as toxic spills. Most executives of major firms also have elaborate views on key, on-going field-level issues like climate change, and draw upon these views frequently.

3. Field-level institutional change requires (a) “reflexivity”; (b) successful “theorization”; and (c) a supportive institutional infrastructure. These related institutional factors imply that in order to gain competitive advantage, a senior manager must increase his/her active awareness of environmental and social issues, use the language appropriate to them, and craft new concepts and practices around them. Traditionally, senior managers have been less able to recognize and translate exogenous and endogenous into vibrant within-field

discourse and novel practice, compared to doing so in an institutional field such as, say, banking. The climate change information that was discussed in the Rio Accord and led to the Kyoto Protocol came to be heavily debated ten years later, stalling true progress in the US on cleaner air. Some already theorized programs are a useful place for a senior executive to overcome such inertia. The Natural Step (Robert, 1989) offers a coherent set of terms, theory, and associated practices for sustainability that has gained currency in the institutional field. More recently, former Sierra Club President, Adam Werbach (2009) has developed a training program about the basics of sustainability and how to negotiate on its behalf within a firm, which he has used with thousands of executives. A senior manager would benefit from learning about either and translating their sets of practices into those applicable for her or his firm.

In addition, given the underdeveloped nature of the institutional infrastructure for environmental and social issues, compared to that for more standard legal and business issues, a senior manager has the opportunity to create, and then engage with, field-level organizations devoted to sustainability. Today, transnational organizations are essential for generating and diffusing discourse and practice concerning environmental and social issues. By generating a transnational organization in a new issue area—such as one concerned with the rapidly declining critical oceanic nutrients (plankton and brine shrimp), or perhaps with the lack of financial and legal rights for poor entrepreneurs receiving microfinance—senior managers can make a big difference in an institutional field for sustainability.

4. There is typically a heterogeneity of responses to institutional demands...and also a variety of opportunity spaces for institutional and astute institutional entrepreneurs/organizations. A senior manager today must recognize that where sustainability is concerned there is much greater breadth and latitude for strategic response in institutional fields than previously existed. Two decades ago, there was more emphasis on regulation, compliance, and isomorphic response, with governments making up for market failure by inserting themselves in various industrial sectors. Currently, governments are more likely to allow a range of responses. In energy sectors, there are emissions permits with volume and time varying ceilings, cap-and-trade systems, carbon offsets, and carbon taxes. A senior manager must, therefore, strategize more fully to explore and exploit institutional possibilities. S/he needs to conceptualize a whole portfolio of approaches to sustainability based on the institutional development of the various subfields and how entrepreneurial a management wishes to be with regard to these different domains.

This new situation is not without its own perils. On the one hand, the heterogeneity in the sector allows a senior manager and his/her firm to craft unique positions within specific fields for sustainability (for example, greenhouse gases, water quality, genetically modified foods) and also a more unique, overall identity for the firm. These days firms that claim to be “different” in the way they handle these issues is large, compared to thirty years ago, when there

were only a few firms like Patagonia and the Body Shop with sustainability-oriented approaches. On the other hand, without much commonality in idea, practice, and identity among firms within an institutional field, not only will a firm's particular approach become difficult for stakeholders to discern, but the field will not have enough collective focus to pursue a coherent set of sustainability practices. The trick for a senior manager, then, is to find—or construct—these central tendencies via reflexivity and theorization and to position his or her firm more uniquely around them. For years, BP Oil earned “green dividends” by trumpeting its lead in emissions reduction technologies and clean energy via their green marketing campaigns compared to other “oil majors,” even if eventually the lack of investment in maintenance and safety undermined that effort.

5. Organizational-level change is a consequence of four, more proximate factors: (1) **organizational positions;** (2) **organizational structures (that determine whether logics are “represented”);** (3) **ownership and governance arrangements;** and (4) **the identity of the specific organization.** In the case of fields involving sustainability logics and their manifestations, a senior manager needs to use his/her firm's position in the field's infrastructure and its network linkages with field members to pursue various sustainability opportunities. As mentioned, peripheral positions may yield higher rates of experimentation, as they have with forestry practices; whereas more central positions may lead to competitive dynamism and attempts at disruption in the core, as they did with GE's creation and widespread use of Six Sigma. At the same time, a senior manager needs to be sure to selectively represent the institutional field in that structural position: not all voices from the field can or should be heard inside the firm. Instead, institutional theory suggests that those voices aligned with key areas of discourse and theorization at the field level, along with the firm's specific sustainability initiative, need to be brought inside the organization and given a role in shaping its operation. In the case of forestry, this was true in British Columbia when environmentalists were brought into the pulp and paper company, MacMillan Bloedel, via the Joint Solutions Project, and it was true for the Japanese manufacturing organizations that brought in Malcolm Baldrige to train them in Six Sigma.

A senior manager of an organization in a field involved with sustainability may also need to modify the firm's ownership and governance to align with the field. Sustainability-related fields are well known for having many strong stakeholders who have theorized and promoted extensive methods of consultation and representation. As a result, a senior manager of a firm in such a field should expect to have more advisory committees, formal consultation techniques, and a more diverse board than s/he would in a firm in, say, high technology. There is also evidence that family firms and firms with other strong links to the community are likely to embrace sustainability and, in turn, for fields that are involved with sustainability to allow such forms of ownership to flourish. As a result, a senior manager should anticipate that the field's members and the firm's employees will likely expect more participation and a

more benevolent style of management in the firm. The Body Shop was well known for giving employees one day off per week to pursue social and environmental initiatives. Green firms as a whole appear to have more progressive HR policies, including more training and flexible schedules, than non-green ones.

6. **The implementation of change inside the organization involves (a) similar processes and mechanisms . . . to those operating at the field level; and (b) the skillful hybridizing of practices . . . to enhance the organization's legitimacy.** Reflexivity and theorization are essential for institutional change at the organizational level. Thus, as noted earlier, using language and mobilizing actors around new ideas and practices are essential skills for senior managers hoping to generate institutional change. Various external and internal sustainability experts can help. These experts have spent time thinking about sustainability and offer a ready-made language and set of mobilization techniques for a senior manager. For example, at Mountain Equipment Co-op (MEC), senior managers encourage co-op members in various communities interested in sustainability to pitch new initiatives, such as using organic fibers and heritage building sites. Similar policies are used at Patagonia and REI. In this way, many field-level processes can be translated into firm-level ones.

Once there is representation of field-level voices in the firms—especially of expertise via use of professionals—a senior manager may feel compelled to hybridize his/her firm. Such is the case with Khosla Ventures, a VC originally more dedicated to investing in high technology, which then moved heavily into biofuels. Today, even with the downturn in clean technology, Khosla Ventures has kept part of its portfolio in the clean-energy sector. The VC's CEO, Vinod Khosla, former co-founder and CEO of Sun Microsystems, continues to be an important voice both in the clean-energy and high-tech industry. Senior managers like Khosla must identify new “balance points” for hybrid firms around competing logics and to empower members to reach such points.

Conclusion to sustainability and organizational change

With these various field- and firm-level actions, the senior manager should be able to move her/his firm further in the direction of sustainability, where sustainability is development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. As we have seen, sustainability changes over time as a field evolves, depending on the degree of the heterogeneity of that field and firm-level practice. Currently, the field is becoming ever more global, with linkages among its economic, environmental, and social systems. Such linkages normally imply the need for

increased coordination and cooperation. Yet we are also seeing increasing calls for more regulation and control. How then can we avoid returning to the unproductive oscillation between cooperative versus command and control approaches that characterized the 1970s and 1980s?

To match with this evolving, new set of sustainability pressures, ideas, and practices, some experts suggest it is important to find key configurations among firms in fields that allow for “generative” clusters, ones where the hybrids are tripartite, being composed of economic, social, and environmental practices, as they hold the most promise. Such is the case of particular co-gen energy regions of Germany, where social and economic experiments in manufacturing have led to energy efficiencies. Another case is in Costa Rica, where farmers, tourism firms, and biological reserves have formed durable cooperatives (for example, around Monteverde). Identifying the balance point among these systems and sets of generative practice across them will allow such complex organization to flourish. Indeed, the institutional approach is well suited to assessing the new pluralism among logics of sustainability. It has always wrestled with the paradox of the closing iron cage due to inexorable institutional forces versus the highly disruptive nature of large-scale institutional change. Our chapter’s goal has been to illuminate this dynamic in the context of sustainability. We hope the reader departs with a greater understanding of it and somewhat different methods for handling sustainability issues.

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